the enlargement of the membership of EC. In 1973 the Communities enlarged to include Denmark, the Republic of Ireland, and the United Kingdom. Norway had negotiated to join at the same time but a referendum rejected its membership and so it remained outside. Greece, Spain and Portugal joined in the 1980s. In 1995, Austria, Sweden and Finland joined the newly established EU. Since then, the Eurozone has increased to encompass 16 countries, with Slovakia joining the Eurozone on 1 January, 2009. In 2004, the EU saw its biggest enlargement to date when Malta, Cyprus, Slovenia, Estonia, Latvia, Lithuania, Poland, the Czech Republic, Slovakia and Hungary joined the European Union. On 1 January 2007, Romania and Bulgaria became the EU's newest members and Slovenia adopted the Euro.

The European Constitution was signed on 28 October 2004. Ratification of the treaty was primarily by parliamentary approval but some states held referenda during 2005. The French and the Dutch voters rejected it. Next, in December 2007, the European leaders signed the Lisbon Treaty which was to be ratified before the end of 2008 so that it could come into force on 1 January 2009. This was intended to replace the earlier, failed European Constitution. However, the future of the Lisbon Treaty is also unclear because of its rejection by the Irish voters in June 2008.

## Stages of European Integration

1949— The North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) signed.

1950— The Schuman Plan proposed.

1951— The European Coal and Steel Community established with 6 founding members (Belgium, Federal Republic of Germany, France, Italy, Luxembourg and the Netherlands).

1952— The Nordic Council formed to augment cooperation among Denmark, Finland, Iceland, Norway and Sweden.

1954— The Paris Treaty setting up the Western European Union (WEU).

1958— The Treaties of Rome set up the European Economic Community (EEC) and the European Atomic Energy Community (Euratom).